

Psalms 53

The Fool Hath Said in His Heart

The fool hath said in his heart, There is no God

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *The fool hath said in his heart, There is no God. Corrupt are they, and have done abominable iniquity: there is none that doeth good.*
- 2 *God looked down from heaven upon the children of men, to see if there were any that did understand, that did seek God.*
- 3 *Every one of them is gone back: they are altogether become filthy; there is none that doeth good, no, not one.*
- 4 *Have the workers of iniquity no knowledge? who eat up my people as they eat bread: they have not called upon God.*
- 5 *There were they in great fear, where no fear was: for God hath scattered the bones of him that encampeth against thee: thou hast put them to shame, because God hath despised them.*
- 6 *Oh that the salvation of Israel were come out of Zion! When God bringeth back the captivity of his people, Jacob shall rejoice, and Israel shall be glad.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 53 closely parallels Psalm 14, with small variations (using "Elohim" for God throughout and a different ending about the enemy). Henry notes the repetition itself is instructive—universal depravity needed restating, and God repeats truths for our slow hearts. MacArthur-style notes read "fool" as moral, not merely intellectual, folly: practical atheism that fuels corruption.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

"The fool hath said in his heart, There is no God. Corrupt are they, and have done abominable iniquity." God looks down from heaven and finds none who understands, none who seeks Him—"they are all together become filthy." Denial of God is the root of universal corruption, not merely a private opinion.

Verse 4-5

"Have the workers of iniquity no knowledge? who eat up my people..." they call not upon God, yet great fear will overtake them when God scatters the bones of besiegers—shame comes because God despises them. Judgment falls even on those who feel secure in oppression.

Verse 6

"Oh that the salvation of Israel were come out of Zion! ...God bringeth back the captivity of his people." The psalm ends turning from complaint to hope for God-given deliverance and communal joy.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Denying God is not neutral; it corrupts conduct and community. Yet the psalm does not end in cynicism—it closes longing for salvation "out of Zion," pointing every generation toward the deliverance only God can bring for a fallen people.

Application for life today.

Watch for practical atheism in yourself—living as if God does not see, even while professing belief. Let this psalm shape compassion, not superiority, toward a corrupt culture, since Scripture says none does good apart from grace. Let longing for God's salvation, not mere social critique, be your final response to evil in the world.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no "right length" answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. In what areas of life are you tempted to live as if "there is no God," even without saying it?

2. How does verse 3's universal indictment shape the way you view people who seem far from God?

3. What would it look like to genuinely long, like verse 6, for God's saving work rather than just complain about corruption?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).